

STREET THEATRE
Mamata Banerjee at the dharna against the Centre in Kolkata, Mar. 29

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WEST BENGAL

MAMATA SITS FIRM AGAINST THE CENTRE

By Romita Datta

A slow crisis has been engulfing rural West Bengal, affecting tens of thousands of labourers. Around 10 million people, despite having MNREGA job cards, have had no work over the past one year, nor have most been paid for the work done under the central jobs scheme. It resulted in massive joblessness and migration out of the state in 2022. NREGA Sangharsh Manch, a civil rights group, also claims that over 10 million may have been affected. The ostensible reason for the Centre withholding funds for the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act and the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY) is the allegation of widespread corruption in the administration and the ruling Trinamool Congress. The issue has been politicised for long—the TMC has blamed the Centre's 'vendetta politics' for the withholding of funds; the principal opposition BJP has alleged that the situation arose from rampant corruption.

With the panchayat polls about a month away, it is politically imperative for West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee to send the message to the state's 56.6 million rural voters that it is the Centre, and not the state, that is responsible for their predicament. Her 31-hour overnight sit-in protest from the afternoon on March 29 before the B.R. Ambedkar statue on Red Road in the heart of Kolkata ticked all the boxes: allegations of discrimination and economic blockade against the Modi government, invocation of Bengali pride in defying the BJP's alleged designs and a call for national Opposition unity.

The Centre had been holding back MNREGA funds since December 2021 by invoking section 27 of the Act, which calls for the measure in the event of improper utilisation of the sanctioned amount. In July 2021, after on-the-spot investigations, central teams collated evidence of alleged embezzlement, creation of ghost work and workers and other malpractices. The Centre imposed fines on the district administrations of Hooghly, East Bardhaman, Malda and Darjeeling and asked the state to rectify the wrongs and recover the fine amount from panchayat members involved in alleged irregularities. The state claims that despite having clarified its position on the various red flags raised, the Centre had been illegally holding on to Rs 2,744 crore on account of wages for work already done. According to Rajya Sabha MP and TMC leader Sukhendu Sekhar Roy, the Centre owes Rs 7,300 crore on account of MNREGA and Rs 8,200 crore for PMAY. "We demand a white paper by the Union government giving details of how many central teams have visited other states, particularly BJP-ruled ones, to find out discrepancies in the implementation of flagship schemes," Roy says.

From her dharna site, Mamata repeated the charge that the Centre was depriving the people of Bengal of their legitimate dues. "I am sitting for the rights of common people whose money has been blocked by the Centre. If required, Mamata can even sit on a dharna near the PM's house," she asserted.

WHILE DENOUNCING THE BJP, MAMATA ALSO CALLED FOR A UNITED OPPOSITION FOR THE 2024 LOK SABHA POLLS

The Opposition BJP has stuck to its guns—alleging that the TMC was selective in the distribution of 100 days of work under MNREGA and allotment of houses under PMAY, thus creating its own coterie of beneficiaries at the expense of genuinely needy people. Its accusations gained credence as there was intense anger throughout Bengal over TMC leaders and loyalists allegedly cornering